

■ By Priya Sahgal

Curiouser and curiouser," cried Alice in Wonderland. Rahul Gandhi is echoing the same sense of wonderment as he scampers about the countryside, visiting tribals and discovering Dalits.

When his Bel Air chopper landed at a Naxal-dominated village in Bastar, Chhattisgarh, recently, he was shocked to realise that the policies of the Government do not reach the people at the grassroots level. In April, when his SUV braked to a halt at Kalahandi in Orissa, he was amazed to see the other India, dispossessed and forgotten. A reality check here: did he have to travel hundreds of miles to discover the obvious? Then again, this is the story of a somewhat-bemused heir apparent as he steps outside the dynastic bubble and discovers the wonder that is India.

As he goes about his self-appointed mission, the young Gandhi-in-waiting is all earnestness. He asks villagers in Karnataka if they have heard about the NREG scheme. They shake their heads. He squats on the grass next to them and launches into an explanation of the UPA Government's flagship scheme, one that he has chosen to champion. In Orissa's Bhawanipatana he tells the tribals, "In 2008, a very important bill was passed by the Parliament, an important bill for our brothers and sisters, the Tribal Bill. Through this bill you will have security of your land." Later, at an interaction with Youth Congress workers in Raipur, he asks all those who know English to raise their hands. Only seven of the over-1000-strong crowd do. He tells them that while it is good to know their local dialect, the importance of English, science and mathematics cannot be ignored in today's India.

There is little doubt that the 37-year-old is slowly grooming himself to lead the 123-year-old party. "I will not move according to someone else's timetable. I will do things only when I am ready to do them," he told a friend recently. Later, at an interaction with the media, he said, "I'm basically doing the groundwork right now. I have to look into the status of things." Despite the smile on his face, there is an impatience with such questions that need

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